

BigBlueButton: The Handy Web Conferencing Software

BigBlueButton is open source VoIP conferencing software that enhances regular as well as distance learning. It can also be used to extend the effectiveness of Moodle.

BigBlueButton is Voice over IP (VoIP) based Web conferencing software. This tool is helpful for remote learning, virtual classrooms, distance education, online learning, etc. Some of the features of BigBlueButton include:

- Recording and playing back the entire session
- Whiteboard for lectures (similar to a blackboard in a classroom)
- Desktop sharing
- Integrated VoIP for listening and speaking
- Presentations (any PDF or presentation file can be uploaded for teaching)
- Webcam that can be shared between users
- Private and group chat (in case the teacher wants to chat with a student, or the students and teachers want to chat within a group)

This tool is completely open source and the API is provided for deployment in a local server. There is also a developer version available for continuous development of the software.

BigBlueButton displays three windows within a browser. The left side window shows the list of users that have joined during the session, the Web camera controls, as well as the audio and video controls. The middle window shows the whiteboard on which the teacher can write, scribble, type, draw, etc, and which can be broadcast to all the viewers. And the right side window is a chat window, in which all the users chat as a group or individually—with the teacher or other users (see Figure 5 for more details).

Installing BigBlueButton in Ubuntu

BigBlueButton recently released version 0.9.0 that can be installed mainly on an Ubuntu 14.04 OS, which is released with long term support (LTS). Table 1 gives the recommended prerequisites for installation in a server.

Installation of BigBlueButton in a server is a long process. It involves the downloading of around 500MB of software, and takes two to three hours to complete.

Before installing the software, the following things have to be checked:

